

Public Comment: Rethinking Policing and Public Safety in Kennett Township

Good evening. My name is Monica Strauser, and I am a resident of Kennett Township. I am here again to raise a fundamental question: *Does the proposed police facility and staffing model actually fit the needs of our community?*

According to the township's own **2025 Kennett Township Police Department statistics**, our community experiences a *low level of violent crime*, with most calls to the police being **non-criminal service and community assistance calls** — welfare checks, traffic issues, alarms, and similar calls that are about *service* more than *crime*.

Yet the proposed plan envisions a large, specialized facility with spaces designed for *criminal processing and detention* — even though those functions constitute only a tiny fraction of the department's daily workload. Residents have repeatedly asked why we are building for an assumption that our department must operate like a city force, when the reality is very different.

This mismatch highlights a deeper issue: Are we asking the *right questions about public safety*? More specifically, should we continue to rely only on a *traditional, sworn, armed police model* for most calls, or should we explore alternative models better suited to a modern, low-crime community?

Around the country, jurisdictions are increasingly experimenting with **co-responder and mobile crisis team models**. In these programs, police officers work alongside mental health clinicians or social workers — or, in some cases, trained civilian responders independently handle low-risk 911 calls involving mental health, substance use, homelessness, or verbal disputes. These teams divert people away from the criminal justice system and toward appropriate care, and help reduce unnecessary escalation when there is *no immediate threat of violence or danger*.

Examples range from mobile crisis teams that respond directly to behavioral health calls to co-response units pairing clinicians with officers. The point is not to remove police entirely, but to **right-size our response** so that skilled, unarmed professionals can handle many situations that do *not* require police or the use of force. This can conserve resources, reduce long-term costs, and provide more effective support for residents in crisis.

Our township currently has an 11-officer force that covers most of the day, with the Pennsylvania State Police filling overnight hours. That hybrid model already acknowledges that we do not need a full 24/7 local police force. If the vast majority of calls are non-emergency, perhaps we should be asking: *Why continue to staff most calls with armed officers when there are proven alternatives?*

The conversation around public safety in Kennett must evolve beyond “**the next building**” and begin focusing on **what kind of response we want and need** in 2026 and beyond. How do we ensure our residents are served by the right responder at the right time? How do we make sure that when someone calls for help — whether it’s a welfare check, a mental health crisis, or a service request — they are met with competence, compassion, and appropriate training?

Our current policing model works well for certain situations, but it may not be the right tool for every call. We should be exploring models like co-responders, Behavioral Health Units, and community-based crisis teams that can handle non-criminal calls effectively and humanely. These models do not undermine public safety — they *refine* it.

Most importantly, because our police are serving mostly community service functions, the **facility we build should reflect that role**, not an outdated assumption that police always need costly, specialized spaces designed around criminal detention. We should be allocating taxpayer dollars toward public safety *and well-being*, not locking ourselves into a system that may not match the reality of the work being performed.

Before the township commits to decades of expenses tied to a specific model of policing, I urge the Board to consider whether there are **better, more cost-effective, and more community-oriented ways** to provide public safety — and to ask the public that very question.

Thank you.